

01100100 Beyond
01100101 Screens
01110100
01101111
01111000 A digital detox initiative

Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) & Internet Addiction

Why It's So Hard to Log Off

FOMO stands for Fear of Missing Out. It's that uneasy feeling you get when you think other people are doing something exciting or fun and you're not part of it.

On the internet, FOMO shows up when:

- You keep checking your phone so you don't miss a post, story, or update.
- You feel bad seeing your friends hang out without you.
- You feel pressure to respond instantly to messages.
- You scroll through social media even when you're not enjoying it.

Why FOMO Feeds Internet Addiction

Apps and websites are designed to keep you hooked. They trigger FOMO by:

- Showing only the best parts of other people's lives.
- Sending constant notifications.
- Rewarding quick responses (like streaks, likes, or being "first").

FOMO makes it feel urgent to be online, even when you'd rather rest, focus, or just disconnect.

How FOMO Affects You

- Low mood: You feel left out or "not good enough."
- Poor sleep: You stay up late scrolling.
- Distraction: You find it hard to focus in class or while studying.
- Pressure to perform: You feel like you have to post and stay active online.

Another concept closely linked to FOMO is **Locus of Control**. In simple terms, Locus of control is who you think controls what happens in your life.

- If you have an internal locus of control, you believe you are in charge, you make your own choices.
- If you have an external locus of control, you feel like other people or things control your life like pressure from friends, trends, or social media.

When FOMO is high and you feel like you have to be online all the time, it means your sense of control is outside yourself. The more you feel in charge of your own time and choices, the easier it is to avoid getting stuck online.

Managing FOMO in the Digital World

FOMO can make it really hard to unplug, but with a few simple strategies, you can feel more in control, less anxious, and more present in your real life.

Reality Check the Scroll

- **Remember:** What people post online is filtered and edited.
- **Try this:** Try to change the narrative *"This is their best 10 seconds, not their full day."*

Schedule Screen-Free Time

- Choose **specific hours** in your day when you stay offline (e.g. during meals, study time, before bed).
- Start small, even 30 minutes counts.

Mute, Unfollow, or Turn Off Notifications

- Mute accounts or group chats that make you anxious or drain your energy.
- Turn off app alerts that constantly pull you in, especially social media, games, or shopping apps.

Strengthen Real-Life Connections

- FOMO shrinks when your offline life feels full.
- Plan **real-world hangouts**, family time, or do something creative just for yourself.

Journal Your Triggers

Ask yourself:

- What am I feeling before I scroll?
- Do I feel better or worse after?
- What was I really looking for?